Chenyi (Skylar) Ding

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Research Interests: computational psycholinguistics, surprisal theory, sentence processing, word learning, language acquisition, bilingualism

EDUCATION

University of California, Davis Davis, CA
Master of Arts in Linguistics Sep 2025 – Expected Jun 2027

- GPA: 3.96/4.00; Advisor: Emily Morgan

University of Liverpool (at Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University) Suzhou, China
Bachelor of Arts with Honours in English Studies, Upper Second Class Sep 2021 – Jul 2025

- Thesis: "The Joint Influence of Proficiency and Cognitive Processing Efficiency on L2 Predictive Sentence Processing" (Supervisor: Hong Liu)

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed

Ding, C., Houghton, Z. N., & Jasbi, M. (2026). Reading acquisition order out of BabyLM representations: Child-scale training produces developmentally aligned semantic spaces. Proceedings of the BabyLM Workshop at EMNLP 2026, Budapest, Hungary. 250–259.

Revise and resubmit

Ding, C., & Liu, H. The joint influence of proficiency and cognitive processing efficiency on L2 predictive sentence processing. *Second Language Research*.

PRESENTATIONS

Ding, C., & Morgan, E. Decomposing language model surprisal reveals differential cue weighting in L1 and L2 reading. **2027 Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA)**, San Francisco, CA, Jan 2027. Oral presentation.

Ding, C., Houghton, Z. N., & Jasbi, M. Children's word-learning order is already in their input: Age of acquisition in the semantic space of a child-scale language model. **51st Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 51)**, Boston, MA, Nov 2026. Poster.

Ding, C., Chen, S., Zhao, Z., Ye, M., & Frey, S. Measuring pragmatic difficulty in LLM-based content analysis: Semantic entropy as a diagnostic for variable-level reliability. **12th International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC²S²)**, Burlington, VT, Jul 2026. Talk.

Ding, C., Chen, S., Zhao, Z., Ye, M., & Frey, S. Why here and not there? A pragmatic account of selective failures in LLM-based construct extraction. **Communication Horizons @ UC Davis 2026: Communication in the Age of AI and Algorithms**, Davis, CA, May 2026. Talk.

Ding, C., Chen, S., Zhao, Z., Ye, M., & Frey, S. Pragmatic vulnerability in academic discourse: Using semantic entropy to predict where LLMs fail. **12th Annual UC Davis Symposium on Language Research (CLR)**, Davis, CA, May 2026. Talk.

SKILLS

Programming: Python, R
Statistics: Linear/logistic regression, mixed-effects models, Bayesian methods
Experimental: Eye-tracking (Tobii Pro Lab, Tobii Pro Spectrum, EyeLink), Gorilla, PsychoPy, E-Prime, Praat, Audacity, Qualtrics
Languages: Chinese (native), English (proficient), Japanese (basic)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Department of Linguistics, University of California, Davis Fall 2025 – Fall 2026
Teaching Assistant, "Introduction to Linguistics" (Fall 2025, Winter 2026), "English Grammar" (Spring 2026), "Computational Linguistics" (Fall 2026); Grader, "Topics in Sign Language Linguistics" (Fall 2026)

- Led discussion sections, held office hours, and graded assignments and exams.

SERVICE AND MEMBERSHIPS

Reviewer: BabyLM Workshop 2026 (EMNLP); International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC²S²); UC Davis Symposium on Language Research (CLR)
Member: Linguistic Society of America (LSA)